

Price Watch

The latest up-to-date prices of all the gadgets you would want to buy this month

Killer Rigs

We have a combination of PC configurations for most budgets out there, including the combo of our test rig

Of online data storage

Which cloud backup solution to use when offline data storage just isn't enough?

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Long ago, I anticipated a problem to hit all our lives once they went digital. But not until a couple of years ago did I truly start taking steps to get a grip on it. The problem? The exploding, absolutely mind-numbing amount of data we were generating, not just consuming. And there's a big difference between the two. Photos and videos shot through your smartphone camera, even higher resolution images and 1080p videos captured through that fancy new DSLR you bought in Diwali, and soon enough you'd have scurried around to buy an external hard drive to store all of these precious moments. But if you're like me, who's taken up a massive family project of digitizing every film camera photo captured since the early '50s, offline data storage costs can spiral out of control, and hard drives don't last forever either. How many redundancies can you maintain?

It's when I started investing in online data storage. Not before I had tried a whole hog of free services like Dropbox, Box.com, Flickr, and others. The thing about free storage is that it's good to try out at first, but not something you'd want to depend on wholeheartedly. Free service providers tend to hold back on features and efficiency of service that they otherwise provide to paying customer, in my experience. What's even more important is that unless you pay for a service, you



aren't entitled to fully question how it functions. If a service is free or in beta, chances are that it can get away with anything by a mere apology – if there's loss of data or server downtime, you can't hold them accountable, unless you pay for their services.

For anyone who doesn't want to spend a dime and backup all their photos (not videos), then Flickr is a great option to start off with, especially since it gives 1TB of free storage. The only problem with Flickr is it doesn't have a good bulk photo uploader in its repertoire right now, but if you can plow through this minor road bump, then it's a great early option to explore. Flickr has a paid option too, in case you fall in love with the service. Con-

venience of use, especially uploading from a PC, was my biggest concern here.

I then explored paid hosting with both Amazon Cloud Drive and Google. I paid \$25 per year for 50GB of storage on Amazon for a year, and loved the experience, especially since it has a smartphone app that immediately syncs all your phone photos in the cloud (much like Dropbox). With Google, I persevered with paying \$2 per month for an additional 100GB of storage on top of the 15GB I had through Gmail. Cost-wise, Google was cheaper than Amazon, but both of these cloud storage giants couldn't solve my basic problem. Space. With the volume of personal data I was generating, I calculated that I would run out of both Google and Amazon's storage limits within a year. Not the most economical way out for me, unfortunately.

What I've recently signed up for is a game-changing offer from Microsoft, who's trying to make a big push into the cloud storage market. Through its Office 365 Home plan, for an annual cost of ₹4,199 (or \$70), I stand to get up to 5TB of data storage through OneDrive. That is hands down much greater than Flickr, Amazon, Google or Dropbox. OneDrive works much the same way on a phone (through an app) or Windows or Mac computer (through a constantly synced folder), therefore it's super convenient. What's more, recently Microsoft announced that all paying customers of Office 365 are entitled to unlimited data storage through OneDrive. So, I'm literally paying just under ₹400 per month for backing up all the data I want into the cloud, and be able to access it through anywhere that has an Internet connection. As per convenience, ease of use, and data storage limit, OneDrive access through Microsoft Office 365 is the most economical cloud backup solution available on the

